

I've kept a very messy and very sparse journal since I was a kid, like an afterthought to my daily life, and it has kind of served as a personal time capsule. Since Building 21 has been a huge part of my life this semester, I figured I would share some mentions of B21 here. Not as personal or as detailed as I would've liked, but it certainly brings back a lot of memories for me. This is a transcript (I tried to be as faithful as possible) since my handwriting is indecipherable when not for marks.

Nov 26th Wed

On a morning run I had the idea of sonifying neural nets potentially thru cellular automata.

I went to the B21 info session.

Dec 3rd Wed

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I got into this conversation with Andy¹ [...] he mentioned he was interested in the psychological kind of interpretability studies³. I suggested finding some upper year psych student to collaborate with since he doesn't have time to take a lot of psych courses. That idea kind of came from B21.

Dec 3rd 4th Thu

I was at B21 twice today, once for the guest speaker and again for Henrique's workshop on linear regression of which me and Alex were the only audience⁴.

Dec 10th Wed

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Also last night I wrote this:

comprehensible → incomprehensible (beautiful) → miscomprehensible⁵

Dec 12th Fri

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Then I went to Henrique's linear regression workshop, where he went through the probabilistic interpretation of linear regression.

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¹ My brother.

² Unrelated slander omitted.

³ Stumbled a bit over my words here. I probably meant applying methods of studying human psychology to AI models.

⁴ I still struggle to say this in a grammatically correct way.

⁵ Light green sticky note.

Jan 9th Fri

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B21 orientation was at 5. It was a vibe. There were way more people than I thought. I ended up in a discussion that just because the universe is infinite doesn't mean there's another you somewhere.

BTW my project is about finding non-logical alternatives to interpretability through sound.

Jan 16th Fri

I went to B21 today and after spending some time coding and ultimately generating the wave synthesis code with ChatGPT, we have sonification of a recurrent FashionMNIST classifier!

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I showed the sonification at Lightning [...] Then we talked about languages in the Green room until 6.

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Jan 28th Wed

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I called Andy and he reminded me that rather than trying to replicate papers I should just focus on B21 and leave the rest until reading break or the summer.

Jan 30 Fri

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I fixed the harmonic series bug⁶!! yay!! It had something to do with the ϕ getting too big.

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Feb 10th Tue

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And today I got Nori and ginger for tommorrow.

And I read the *Mysticism of Sonification* article⁷. kinda interesting.

Feb 11th Wed

I went to B21 for sushi potluck! [...] It was mostly organized by Jasmine. Really nice.

Feb 17th Tue

[...] Before that I was at the Michel Hellman talk at B21, where he gave all of us mini sketchbooks.

⁶ The frequencies in the sonification converged to the harmonic series (in other words, it sounded a bit too good to be true).

⁷ *Sonification and the Mysticism of Negation* (Wolfe)

Feb 19th Thu

I was at B21 for 2 hours in the morning working on RCNN⁸ experiments. I should really move on to the Llama.

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Feb 20th Fri

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Then I took Andy to B21. Andy wants to start an interdisciplinary reading/research group.

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Feb 29 Sat

So lots has happened. My B21 project is in a bit of an existential crisis.

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March 3rd Tue

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There was a brainstorming session at B21 in the morning for the Catholic University of Lille. Then I had a meeting with Alex after lunch. [...] I could probably hold off on the theoretical/philosophical doom reading for a bit. I came up with this idea of having a box with the sonification inside.

There was a brainstorming session about the final showcase [...]

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March 4th Wed

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[...] I went to B21 for the Encode Canada event but realized that they didn't have it this week⁹.

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Mar 14th Sat

I ~~figer~~ figured I'd share some good news:

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3. Starting to see the vision of my B21 project in poster form (probably will still do the installation tho)

Mar 16th Mon

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B21. And Calculus and lectures [...]

⁸ This is a personal abbreviation of the recurrent toy classifier model I trained in the beginning of my project.

⁹ They were on reading break.

Mar 19th Thu

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Yeah I mean I got back and was reading the aesthetics chapter of Sonification¹⁰ when I realized that it was just the same questions with no answers [...] Then I had a revelation that I didn't actually have to stick to sonification literature, in fact I could probably stop reading from that field.

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Mar 31st Sat

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I spent the evening at B21 with the first prototype of my project. It was pretty much a box with 2 monitor speakers. I tested some sonification stuff on it; notably, I wrote code for spatialization by network layers. Then I took the thing down in 10 minutes [...] But yeah it was cool.

Mar 29th Sun

Spent the afternoon running Pythia experiments. Finally got to a good normalization¹¹ function that makes sense and sounds good. Behold:

$$\frac{|x|}{2\sigma_x}(20000 - 20) + 20$$

...

Apr 2nd Thu

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Also B21 is in funding trouble apparently.

Apr 9th Thu

The Building 21 showcase was today. I got my poster printed at CopiEUS and then the showcase started at 3 [...] it was very tiring but I got through it yay!

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Apr 14th Tue

Y'all ever heard of the Snake activation function?

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¹⁰ *The Sonification Handbook* (Hermann, Hunt, Neuhoff)

¹¹ This is what I called the function that maps numbers to frequencies, mostly due to old code.